



free will
and
determinism

A large orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, containing the text 'against compatibilist free will' in white, bold, sans-serif font.

**against
compatibilist
free will**

against
incompatibilist
free will

We can lay out this puzzle in terms of the following master argument against the reality of free will.

1. Free will is incompatible with determinism.
 2. If Libertarianism is true, then there is no free will.
-

C. There is no free will.

The master argument against the reality of free will

A compatibility believer in free will rejects premise (1). An incompatibilist believer in free will rejects premise (2).

Let's start with (2), which says that Compatibilism is false.

Now, so far we have been given no reason to think that either premise (2) or premise (3) is true. We're now going to look at two arguments — one for (2), and one for (3).

Compatibilist views of free will can be hard for some to get their minds around. How **could** I have free will if everything about me is, ultimately, determined by factors outside of my control?

It may help to sketch one story of compatibilist theory of free will to help you to see why the view should be taken seriously. What does it take for an action of yours to be free?

Consider the action of choosing a salad at the dining hall. Suppose that
you know that the following are all true:

You picked
the salad.

You wanted
to pick the
salad.

If you had
wanted to pick
something else,
you would have.

If the key to free will is (1) making the choice, (2) wanting to make the choice, and (3) being in a position where if you had wanted to do something different, you could have, then we have a reasonable argument that free will is compatible with determinism.

On this kind of view, if all of (1)-(3) are true, your act is free. Whether or not your choices are ultimately explainable by your genetic inheritance, your upbringing, or other factors outside of your control just doesn't enter into it.

reality of free will.

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1. No one has any choice about events which

then DECISION happens. (3)

happened in the distant past.



of interest.

choice about DECISION (2, 6, 7)

4. If determinism is true, the laws of

if P , then Q , then one has any choice

nature say that if DINS ARE happy,

7. If none has about choice about whether P ,

5. No one has any choice about what the laws

2. None has any choice about DIDS. ATJR.

future is not just what the state of the

6. If $\det A$ is true, then A has any

varlatatie + the last of the

then DECISION. (4,5)

about whether @.



C. If determinist is true, then no one has any

3. If determined, the only one

theorie about the fact that if DNR

and none has any choice about whether,

choice about the laws of nature, then no

This argument seems to show that the

one has any choice about the past, no

combination of four - that No

choice principle, and determinism

rules out free will.

seem quite plausible, the argument

Since the first three of these theses

seems to show that if determinism is



hence that free will is incompatible with

true, there are no free actions — and





The master argument against the reality of free will

believe in free will rejects premise (2).

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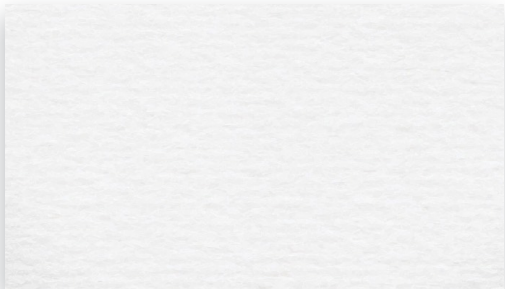
Consider the action of chopping a salad at the dining hall. Suppose that

you know that the following are all true:









salad.



to pick the



wanted to drink

If

you

had

something else,

your world have.

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Real/|the master argument:

tempting to reply to the master argument by denying premise (2).

in free will, and find the consequent argument persuasive, it looks

The consequence argument is a defense of premise (1). If you believe

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A large red circle with a slight drop shadow, containing white text. The text is arranged in three lines, centered within the circle.

**against
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Now that we have a grip on determinism and on our view of free will

deterrinism.

central argument against the view that free will is compatible with

which arguably be compatible with determinism, let's look at the